Silence is Not an Option - A Collection

By Christopher Michael and Denice Frohman

Note: *Links to historical information about the events inspiring each poem can be found at the end of this selection.*

INTRODUCTION

Martin Luther King, Junior once said, "Our lives begin to end the day we become silent about things that matter." Today I choose to raise my voice, silence is not an option.

The Baptist church on 16th Street in Birmingham, Alabama was known as "everybody's church" -- a center for educational and intellectual activities. On September 15, 1963, members of the Ku Klux Klan planted a bomb at the church. It exploded just after Sunday services, killing four young girls and generating international outrage that provided the impetus for passage of the Civil Rights Act of 1964.

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16th Street Baptist Church Speaks
by Christopher Michael

I was born in Birmingham, Alabama in 1911 on 16th
Street.
By born, I mean they finish my construction.
I was erected as an edifice to the Almighty
A place the worship.
A rally point for justice fighters
And a war room for the commanders of the cause.
I can name drop, but that would be rude:
Martin Luther King, Ralph David Abernathy.
Thousands of people release millions of
prayers beneath my roof.
I stood witness to hopes, dreams, marriages and baptisms.
But of all the dignitaries to grace my pews,
The most important, the most precious were Denise, Addy
Mae, Carolyn and Cynthia.
Those 4 girls were visiting me for Sunday school or
something to like.
There's a lot of turmoil in the old days.
I could tell because of all the comings and goings and

whatnot.
Some fuss about integration.
Even our illustrious Governor, George Wallace, has
something to say about the issues of the day.
Let me see, I think what he said was: 'to stop integration,
Alabama needed a few first-class funerals.'
Shortly after, a white gentleman placed a package under
my steps.
At the time I was over 50 years old and I had I grown to
know what the faces of men meant.
Each one told a story or revealed his heart.
I knew that was no gift set before me.
I could feel the spirit of the Lord shutter with grief and I
knew I had to do something, for those four little girls are
still within me.
Girls! Girls you gotta get! Get on from round here!
But maybe, if my steeple wasn't such a tower,
I could do more than babble.
I tried so hard.
I yelled with everything I had:
Girls! Girls you gotta get -- Get on home now!
But all they can hear was me moan and creak like I was

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settling in my foundation.
I was no longer like the servant Peter, I could not be their
rock.
In that split second of eternity, I tried to contain the blast.
I held back the wave of Satan's Hellfire like I hold on every
prayer whispered in my walls.
I used all my strength to stop the embers.
I refused the shards.
I stopped the splitters.
I bound every brick.
I subdued the mortar.
I stood in the gap in the twinkling of an eye,
My God needed to call them home.
And in that moment of forever, they felt the love of my
Lord!
But even eternity must end.
I could not hold back the blast forever and I realized
all I could do was blanket their bodies
in what was left of me.
Swallow them in my destruction.
Tuck them in with my dust.

I won't name the white supremacist who was convicted of
this horrific crime,
But Denise McNair, Addy Mae Collins, Carole Robertson
and Cynthia Wesley transfigured into a spark,
that fans the plains of freedom!
And I,
I had the honor,
I had the . . .
I am so sorry that I could not save you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Christopher Michael
ISBN: N/A
Publisher: Poem Hunter.com
Date (Month/Year): Posted March 17, 2017
On-Line Location:
https://www.poemhunter.com/poem/16th-street-baptist-church-speaks-by-michael-christopher/

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TRANSITION

50 years later, America has evolved, hate crimes are a thing of the past, and we value our countries diversity. Right? . . . Not everyone . . .

On the evening of June 17, 2015, a mass shooter took the lives of nine African American people at a Bible study at Emanuel African Methodist Episcopal Church in Charleston, South Carolina. The massacre at a historic Black church deeply shook a nation already jaded by frequent gun violence and heralded the return of violent white nationalism in America.

The Hour Dylann Roof Sat in the Church by Denice Frohman

I.

By now, you know their names, their cheekbones—
the tender hands they offered when you walked in.

You know the quivering strength of prayer and the art of
making God listen.
How faith can summon weary backbones into pyramids.

And you know that grace still lives in a church that's had to
rebuild itself before—
a church that's cleaned more blood off the walls than you
have ever fantasized of.

That is to say, you're not the first white boy to feel
small and create chaos in someone else's home.

This church is old – much older than you,
wears the audacity of freshly coated white paint

as if to say any ill that smudges
us will be for all to see.

Did you hear the echoes when you walked in? Did you feel
the pastor soothe
the trepidatious voices of ghosts burnt and hung in the
name of *better days*?

So they opened their song for you – shared in head nod and
Bible verse –
not knowing they let in what they spent so much time
praying out

tucked away nearly 400 years of lessons on what it means
to let a white man get too close.

All the bullets in all the world belong to them, yet doors
softened for *you*—
what an unearned miracle.

Do you know what it means to welcome a familiar terror
and hope it got enough God

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on it this time to leave you be? Is there some word greater
than "noble"?

Your predecessors hid their faces, threw Molotov cocktails
from afar
but your ugly is the kind that gets to know what it's about
to kill.

In that hour, were you studying them like elk?
Were you surprised when they prayed for you, even as you
preyed on them?

Did they greet you with too many, *come on ins*?
Did you imagine abandoned prayers?

Did your teeth clench when they said, *God forgives you*?
Did your jaw tighten when they said, *Bless your heart*?

Did their soft voices almost provoke
the rage out of you?

Did you wonder how the hell they were still
standing? Why god hadn't made good on the *fire next
time*?

Did your skin itch when the congregation
said your name like it was worth keeping?

Did you look at their hands? The folds of their skin?
Did you panic then?

Did you forget who the animal was?
Did you leave hoofed, and grunting with a new tail?

Did the gun begin to rattle?
Did the heavy metal fever and sweat?

Did the script get hazy?
Did you forget your lines?

Is that when you almost walked out?

How many crosses did you have to burn
in your head to remember what you came for?

How many names did you have
to unlearn?

II.

Did your hands turn black after you threw your gun down?
Did the bullets pull themselves
out of their skin, and chase you out? Is that why you ran,
boy?

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Why you could stay for Bible study, but not to see what
music God
still offers the dead to keep them warm?

Did you hear your father say, *good job son*? Did you hear
America say, *good job son*?
Did you hear every history textbook write your name?

Did you wink at the police when they searched your
pockets? Did you say, *hey, brother*?
Did they say, *hey*, back?

When you realized they were enjoying you, was it then that
you shot them all?
Was it then that you could not say you enjoyed them too?

When you see God, will he tell you how bad you smell?
Will you say you already know?

A stench like this isn't made overnight,
takes a whole lot of hands
and much longer than an hour.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Denice Frohman
ISBN: N/A
Publisher: SplitThisRock.org
Date (Month/Year): Posted Jul 22, 2016
On-Line Location:
https://www.splitthisrock.org/poetry-database/poem/the-hour-dylann-roof-sat-in-the-church

AWARD HISTORY

2019 National Qualifier

Historical accounts of events referenced in each poem can be found here.

16th Street Baptist Church Bombing:

https://www.history.com/topics/1960s/birmingham-church-bombing

Emanuel African Methodist Episcopal Church Shooting:

https://www.history.com/this-day-in-history/charleston-ame-church-shooting

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